



REAPING BENEFITS:
Members of Ebong Amra
rehearsing at their farm

Theatre in Guava Orchard

A whole village becomes his stage as a man puts together a self-sufficient artistes' commune

■ By Elora Sen

No Ekalavya, you can't cut off your thumb to pay your *gurudakshina*. It belongs to all of us," the heart-wrenching cry rents the air. The scene, reminiscent of Ekalavya's fate in *Mahabharata*, is different from what we are familiar with and so is the scenario—artists enacting a play in a poverty-stricken village.

The creator, Kallol Bhattacharya is also an exception as he not only dreams big, but has his feet firmly rooted in reality. This allows him to give shape to theatre, his first love, for which he has developed a unique commune in his village.

With the help of the villagers, he and his theatre group, Ebong Amra, have transformed 20 bigha of unused land into a nursery with mango and guava orchards and a poultry farm. This 32-year-old is the great-grandson of Nanigopal Chattopadhyaya, who founded the first school in this small village, Satkahania under Bankathi gram panchayat, near Panagarh, West Bengal. His commune helps in sustaining his passion by catering to his theatre group's financial needs and becomes a tool for the village's development.

After doing his higher secondary, Bhattacharya attended a few theatre workshops. In 1994 he fulfilled his dream of forming a theatre group by setting up Ebong Amra—starting with the sons and daughters of daily labourers. This concep-



tualiser, scriptwriter and director soon realised he needed to give those who worked with him a means of sustenance. "They were scolded at home for straying from daily wage-earning jobs. So I thought I could help them by starting a farm," he says. He created a self-help group, in order to take a loan from the local gramini bank for setting up the farm. In 1997, the Kanksa Panchayat Samiti gave Bhattacharya

mango and guava saplings to start his orchard. "We sell the fruits grown here. The saplings reared in the nursery are bought by the panchayat for their forestation projects," he informs. All group members do their bit, from looking after the chickens to tending to the orchards. The profit is divided between the members and the cost of production. The 30-member group, of which eight are women, has performed in 15 productions, including drama festivals in Kolkata. It uses traditional and tribal arts, various dance forms and music, along with martial arts to add a dab of earthiness.

Bhattacharya ensures that workshops are held where leading actors and dancers such as Sohag Sen, Probir Guha, Bivas Chakraborty and even Ratan Thiam, the legendary theatre personality from Manipur, come to teach his group. While theatre remains his focus, he continues doing his bit for the development of the village by making as many people as possible a part of his endeavour.